

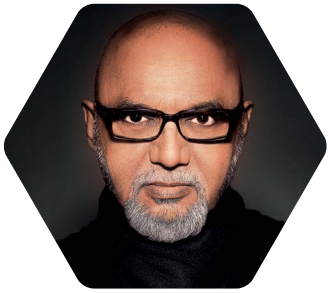
DR DEBENDRA PRADHAN | b. 1941 |

BJP leader and former Union minister

For decades, Pradhan was the organisational backbone of the BJP in Odisha. Often described as the party's 'Bhishma Pitamah' in the state, the doctor-turned-politician left government service for public life, joining the BJP in 1983. He went on to serve three terms as state president and was twice elected to the Lok Sabha. A Union minister of state in the Atal Bihari Vajpayee-led NDA government, he handled portfolios such as surface transport and agriculture. Pradhan—father of Union minister Dharmendra Pradhan—remained a guiding light for the state BJP long after he left active politics.

PRITISH NANDY | b. 1951 |

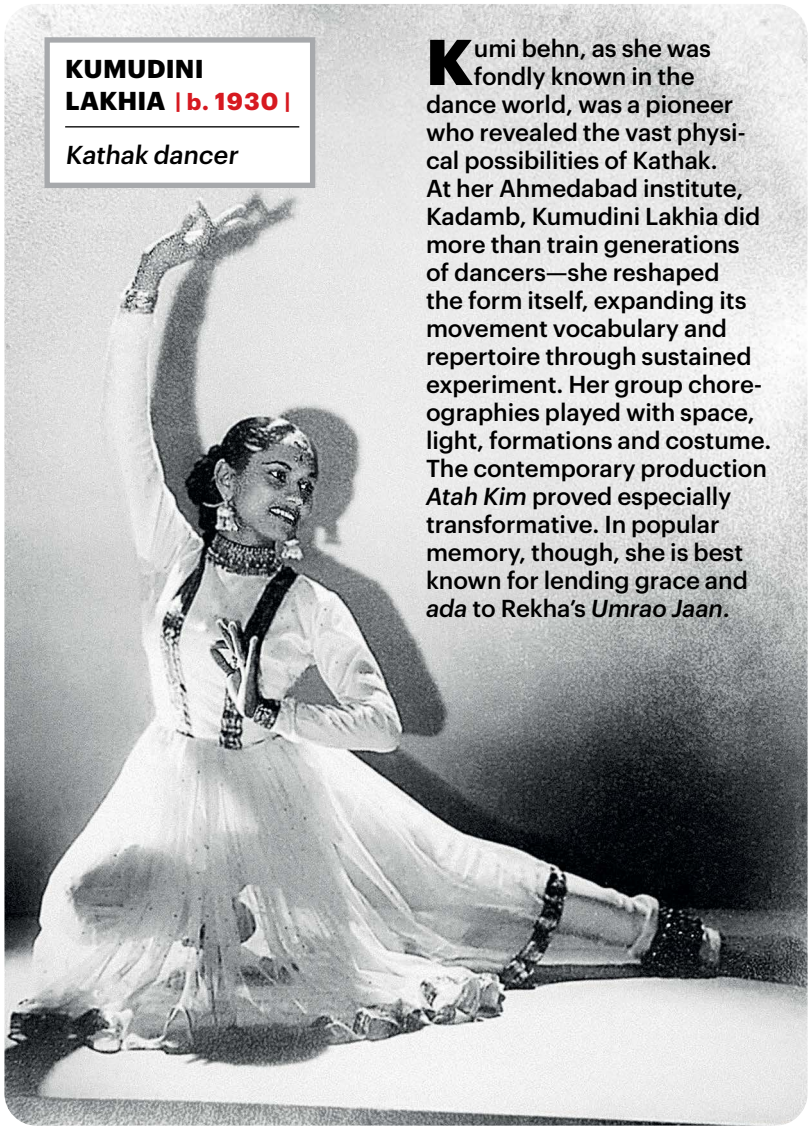
Journalist and film producer



Provocateur, but with a sheen of polish and pizzazz, he was not afraid of controversy—and courted it with relish and, often, barbed wit. The most celebrated product of that was *The Illustrated Weekly* when it was under his charge in the 1980s. He also went from editor—and later a much-watched interview host on DD—to being a publisher, cultural impresario, film production honcho and other walk-on parts that wouldn't seem to have a lot in common. For instance, he was a failed dabbler in Shiv Sena politics but also a decent exponent of verse in English. Critics accused him of excess, but may have secretly admired the phenomenon that was Pritish Nandy.

KUMUDINI LAKHIA | b. 1930 |

Kathak dancer



Kumi behn, as she was fondly known in the dance world, was a pioneer who revealed the vast physical possibilities of Kathak. At her Ahmedabad institute, Kadamb, Kumudini Lakhia did more than train generations of dancers—she reshaped the form itself, expanding its movement vocabulary and repertoire through sustained experiment. Her group choreographies played with space, light, formations and costume. The contemporary production *Atah Kim* proved especially transformative. In popular memory, though, she is best known for lending grace and *ada* to Rekha's *Umrao Jaan*.